



The mountainous republic

San Marino is dominated by Monte Titano, on which stands La Cesta fortress. Most of the country can be seen from the top. San Marino was the world's smallest republic from 301 CE to 1968, losing the title to the newly independent Pacific island, Nauru.

San Marino



The world's oldest republic and one of its smallest. It is entirely surrounded by Italy.

300s **San Marino** is founded by a Christian stonecutter from Dalmatia, who takes refuge here. A large community is resident in the country by the 400s and manages to retain its independence.

1243 **First Captains General** (joint heads of state) are appointed.

1631 **Independence** is recognized by the papacy.

1797 **After Napoleon invades** Italy, San Marino refuses the expansion he offers at the expense of the surrounding Papal States.

1815 **Congress of Vienna** at the end of the Napoleonic Wars recognizes the independence of the state.

1849 **San Marino offers** refuge to Italian patriot Giuseppe Garibaldi after his failed attempt to expel the Austrians from Italy.

1862 **San Marino signs** friendship treaty with Italy but refuses to join the newly united nation. The treaty has been renewed several times since.

1915–18 **San Marino fights** for Italy in World War I.

1940 **Remains neutral** during World War II, and houses around 100,000 refugees.

1944 **Allied aircraft bomb** the country as they fight the Germans in Italy.

1945–57 **First period of** Communist (PCS) Party rule.

1957–78 **Coalition of Christian** Democrats (PDCS) and Social Democrats comes to power. In 1973 the Social Democrats are replaced by the Socialists (PSS) and the tiny Movement for Statutory Liberties party.

1960 **Women obtain the vote.**

1973 **Women granted** the right to hold public office.

1978–86 **Coalition of** San Marino Communist Party (PCS) and Socialists (PSS) in power.

1986 **Financial scandals** lead to a grand coalition of the PDCS and PCS parties, reelected in 1988.

1988 **Joins Council of** Europe.

1990 **PCS renames itself** the PPDS.

1992 **San Marino** joins the UN.

1992 **The collapse** of communism in Europe sees the Communist Party ousted from the coalition and replaced by the Socialists.

2001 **Communist Party** reforms itself as the Party of Democrats (PdP) and takes 20 percent of the vote in a general election won by the Christian Democrats with 41 percent and the Socialists with 24 percent.

2002 **Introduction of** euro.

Malta



A small island republic in the Mediterranean, once the stronghold of the Knights of St. John.

870 CE **Arab Saracens** seize Malta, which had been successively ruled by the Phoenicians, Carthaginians, Greeks, and Romans.

1091 **Malta is conquered** by the Norman-ruled kingdom of Sicily, and is governed by Sicilian rulers until 1530.

1282 **Malta comes under** Spanish Aragonese rule when Sicily chooses the Aragonese king Peter III to rule them.

1530 **Malta is entrusted** to the Knights of St. John of the Hospital (the Hospitallers) by the Habsburg Emperor Charles V.

1565 **Malta withstands** a lengthy Ottoman siege.

1798 **Napoleon Bonaparte drives** out the Hospitaller Knights. The Maltese rise in rebellion and the island is blockaded by the British.

1800 **The British take** control of Malta.

1802 **The Maltese people** freely request the protection of the British crown, providing their rights and privileges can be preserved.

1814 **British possession** is confirmed by the Treaty of Paris and the 1815 Congress of Vienna.

1921 **Malta is granted** a representative assembly, although this autonomy is revoked at the beginning of World War II.

1929 **Tension grows between** the UK, the Roman Catholic Church, and Italy under Mussolini, who makes territorial claims to the island.

1939–45 **Malta comes under** sustained air and sea attack by the Axis powers throughout World War II and is in a state of constant siege. In 1942 the UK awards Malta and its people the George Cross—

the highest civilian award for bravery—for their resistance. The Allies invade Sicily from Malta in 1943.

1947 **Internal self-government.**

1959 **Self-government** is revoked after talks over possible integration with the UK break down. It is restored in 1962. Malta is the only British colony where integration with the UK is seriously considered.

1947 **Internal self-government.**

1964 **Full independence from** UK within the Commonwealth.

1971–87 **Dom Mintoff's** Malta Labour Party (MLP) in power; it promotes Malta's nonaligned status, ends the UK's naval presence on the island, forges closer ties with Libya, which advises and trains its army, and nationalizes many important industries.

1974 **Malta becomes** a republic within the Commonwealth.

1987–96 **Edward Fenech Adami** of the Nationalist Party (NP) is prime minister and begins talks for Malta to join the EU. His government favors a free-market approach to the economy, deregulating the banking, telecommunications, and trade sectors, introducing much-needed economic and administrative reforms.

1996 **A modernized MLP** under Alfred Sant returns to power; it weakens trade union links and stalls the nation's EU application, but its small parliamentary majority undermines its work.

1998 **Early elections bring** pro-EU Fenech Adami back to power.

2003 **In a referendum,** Maltese vote in favor of EU membership. Fenech Adami wins another term as NP prime minister.

2004 **Fenech Adami becomes** president; Lawrence Gonzi takes over as prime minister.

2004 **Malta finally** joins the European Union.

2008 **Malta adopts** the euro.

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DECISIVE MOMENT

THE SIEGE OF MALTA, 1526

Forced out of Rhodes by the Turks in 1522, the Knights of St. John created a fortress in Malta (right). In 1565 the Turks sent a 30,000-strong army to take the island. The harbor was guarded by the fort of St. Elmo, which held out until June 23. The capture cost the Turks 8,000 casualties. The assault then moved to the inner fortifications but was repulsed by savage fighting. The arrival of a relief force on September 7 convinced the Turks to cut their losses, which had mounted to 24,000. The siege checked the Ottoman advance in the Mediterranean.

